



Committee name: Cabinet

Committee date: 11/02/2026

Report title: Revisions to the Home Options Policy

Portfolio: Councillor Jones, Cabinet Member for Housing

Report from: Director of communities and housing

Wards: All wards

OPEN PUBLIC ITEM

Purpose

To propose changes to the Council's social housing allocations policy to incorporate new legislation and statutory guidance.

Recommendation:

Cabinet is asked to agree the adoption of an updated Home Options policy.

Policy framework

The Council has five corporate priorities, which are:

- An open and modern Council.
- A prosperous Norwich.
- A fairer Norwich.
- A climate responsive Norwich.
- A future-proof Norwich.
- This report meets the 'A fairer Norwich' corporate priority

Background

1. Part VI of the Housing Act determines that local authorities must have an allocation scheme to determine priorities between applicants for social housing and to set out the procedure to be followed when allocating social housing in their area. In Norwich, the allocation scheme is called Home Options.
2. The current Home Options allocations policy ([Norwich Home Options Allocation Scheme | Norwich City Council](#)) dates from October 2021 and needs updating to incorporate new legislation and statutory guidance. The update also

presents the opportunity to ensure that policy reflects local needs and issues.

3. The proposed policy changes, while minimal, take into account legislative changes, statutory guidance ([Providing social housing for local people - GOV.UK](#)) as well as the recently published 'National Plan to End Homelessness' and Government Homelessness Strategy ([A National Plan to End Homelessness - GOV.UK](#)).
4. The proposed changes have recently been subject to public consultation and consideration by the Overview and Scrutiny Committee.
5. The draft revised policy is attached at Appendix A. For ease of reference, the proposed changes are highlighted in the policy and detailed below in paragraphs 7 to 11.
6. An Equality Impact Assessment has been undertaken and is attached as Appendix B.

Proposed changes to policy

7. All applications will involve a discussion of an applicant's housing need with an adviser. Applicants who do not meet the criteria for a priority banding category are extremely unlikely to be rehoused through the Home Options scheme and will be given advice about alternative housing options.
8. In accordance with statutory guidance, and to ensure that the council's housing policies benefit local people, applicants must have been continuously resident in Norwich for at least the last two years. Exceptions, as set down in legislation, will apply.
9. The number of refusals allowed before an application is cancelled for 12 months will be reduced from five to three to reflect extremely high demand for social housing. This will not apply to homelessness clients, who, as required by legislation, receive one offer.
10. Clarification of priority banding for rough sleepers: where it has been confirmed that an applicant is sleeping rough, meets the qualification criteria and it has been assessed that there is no other accommodation available to them, silver band will be awarded by the council's rough sleeper team. The team will carry out a needs-led assessment and use professional judgement to engage and support people sleeping rough in each case. Priority will not be awarded when the client does not engage with the council's support or where accommodation has been made available to the applicant which they have chosen not to accept.
11. In accordance with the Armed Forces Covenant, U.K. armed forces veterans will be prioritised within bands.

Consultation

12. The Home Options policy public consultation took place between 10 November and 12 December 2025. An online survey was hosted on Get Talking Norwich, the council's consultation and engagement platform.
13. A dedicated project page was created for the consultation which, which

included a narrative, the survey, and the Home Options draft policy, Equality Impact Assessment and briefing note. The consultation was additionally shared with relevant stakeholders via email.

14. Key partners were contacted directly and the proposals were taken to a service users group.
15. A total of 72 responses were received.
16. Responses showed broad agreement (see Appendix C) for all proposals and will be published, along with council comments, in an online report.

Consultation key comments

17. In terms of local connection, a respondent raised concerns that people without local connection will remain in hostels longer, blocking move-on pathways.
18. However, this concern can be mitigated as the Council's hostel move-on agreement with supported accommodation providers sets out how the partners will explore alternative housing and reconnection options for residents without a local connection to Norwich, to ensure that people are supported into housing.
19. In regard to armed forces prioritisation, a respondent raised concerns that concerns that veterans may be prioritised over people with disabilities, domestic abuse survivors, or those in unsafe housing, who may be in greater need of accommodation.
20. However, the prioritisation of armed forces members is in alignment with the requirements of the Armed Forces Covenant, to which the council is signatory.
21. In terms of the clarification of the circumstances by which priority banding for rough sleepers will be awarded, several respondents raised that this banding may act as an incentive to individuals to sleep rough to be verified to receive silver priority banding.
22. In response to this concern and to mitigate such a risk, and in accordance with the National Plan to End Homelessness, we have amended the policy proposal to include a needs-led assessment and the use of professional judgement prior to the award of priority banding.

Scrutiny Committee recommendation

23. At Scrutiny Committee on 15 January 2026, the Committee suggested no changes to the proposed amendments to policy (as set out in paragraphs 7 to 11 above).
24. However, Scrutiny Committee did resolve to ask that Cabinet consider removing section 3.8.7.3 of the existing policy from the new policy.

25. Section 3.8.7 of policy sets out that silver band will be awarded where a household has a child aged 10 or under in a flat or maisonette with no private garden. Section 3.8.7.3 sets out that silver band will not be awarded for those children who were born when the current property was accepted.
26. The recommendation from the Scrutiny Committee has been considered by the Portfolio Holder but is not accepted
27. The Portfolio Holder considers that section 3.8.7.3 should remain as now. This policy is designed to ensure that priority banding is not awarded where an applicant's housing circumstances have been created through their own decisions and choices, for example where an applicant with a child moves into a property with no garden and then applies for priority banding on the grounds that the property is therefore unsuitable.
28. Applicants in such circumstances are able to seek alternative options to resolve their situation, for example, through mutual exchange.

Implications

29. There are no proposals in this report that would reduce or increase resources
30. The proposals set out in the report ensure that the council's allocations policy meet legislative requirements, statutory guidance and government strategy.

Other Options Considered

31. No other options have been considered

Reasons for the recommendation

32. The current allocations policy is out of date and needs to be amended to include the latest legislation and statutory guidance. The update also presents the opportunity to ensure that policy reflects local needs and issues.

Appendices:

- A: Proposed 2026 Home Options policy
B: Equality Impact Assessment
C: Consultation response data

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Appendix A - Proposed 2026 Home Options policy

1. Introduction

1.1.1. This allocation policy explains the rules that determine how Norwich City Council (known throughout this document as 'the council') allocates social housing properties. It sets out the priorities and procedures that the council will follow in the letting of social housing to applicants on its housing register.

1.1.2. The Registered Providers (Housing Associations) that are part of the scheme are known throughout this document as 'scheme landlords'. These are listed in Appendix D.

1.2. Background

1.2.1. The allocation scheme is also known as Home Options. Under the scheme, the council and scheme landlords advertise their properties for rent on a weekly basis on its website and invite bids on each property from applicants who are registered with the scheme.

1.2.2. Norwich is an area of very high housing need and demand for social housing far exceeds the supply of accommodation that becomes available. It must be remembered that Home Options does not produce any more affordable housing but provides a fairer, more efficient and transparent way of allocating the social housing available

1.3. Scheme objectives

1.3.1. The key objectives of the scheme are to:

- Meet the legal requirements for the allocation of social housing.
- Focus resources on those in the most need.
- Operate a scheme which is, fair, transparent and easy to use.
- Help meet the housing needs of Norwich residents
- Allow scheme users, through the transparent nature of the scheme, to make informed decisions about their housing options.

- Make best use of Norwich's social housing stock.
- Encourage and support, balanced and sustainable communities.
- Prevent homelessness and reduce the use of temporary accommodation
- Encourage through flow from hostel accommodation in order to reduce rough sleeping.
- Operate the scheme so that it improves accessibility and customer service for vulnerable groups in Norwich.
- Make sure those who have the greatest need for housing have the greatest opportunity to get it
- Pay due regard to the aims of the Norwich Homelessness Strategy and Tenancy Strategy
- Meet the council's corporate priorities of ensuring a fairer city

1.4. Legal framework

1.4.1. This allocation scheme complies with the legal framework for allocating social housing, laid down in the Housing Act 1996 and takes account of statutory government guidance on the allocation of accommodation.

1.4.2. This allocation scheme pays due regard to the Equality Act 2010.

1.4.3. The assessment of eligibility, qualification and assessment of priority for the Home Options scheme will take into account any changes to legislation made subsequent to this policy.

1.5. How does the scheme work?

1.5.1. Home Options is a choice-based lettings scheme. The council and scheme landlords advertise their vacant properties to those on the housing register. The adverts include a detailed description of the property. Applicants on the register can then bid for the property of their choice if they are eligible and meet the qualifying criteria.

- 1.5.2. The successful applicant will be selected from those who have bid for the property and meet the stated qualifying criteria. Selection will be based on the highest band, followed by the banding date where there is more than one applicant from the same band.
- 1.5.3. Feedback will be provided on what demand there was for previously advertised properties. This will help applicants to make informed choices.
- 1.5.4. This policy is available free of charge at the website www.norwich.gov.uk. A paper copy of the full policy is available upon request from City Hall at a cost of £25.00.

2. Application Procedure

2.1. How to apply

- 2.1.1. To apply for a social housing property in Norwich an applicant must be registered with Home Options.
- 2.1.2. Applications to Home Options can be made over the telephone on 0344 980 3333. All applications will involve a discussion of an applicant's housing need with an adviser. Acceptance onto Home Options register is not a guarantee that an applicant will be offered accommodation. Home-Options is unable to meet the needs of all home-seekers and transferring tenants looking for accommodation. Applicants who do not meet the criteria for a priority banding category are extremely unlikely to be rehoused through the Home Options scheme and will be given advice about alternative housing options.
- 2.1.3. Home Options is a scheme which is based on verification. All applicants will be required to provide evidence of their household circumstances including income, savings and housing history.
- 2.1.4. Information to support an application may be asked for at any time. If the information is not provided, the application may be suspended or removed from Home-Options and any offers of accommodation withdrawn. All applicants will be offered help and advice to complete their application. This includes translation and interpreting facilities where required.

2.2. Who can apply?

- 2.2.1. Residents of the UK who are over 18 years old can apply to Home Options however this does not guarantee an application will be taken or that the applicant will be re-housed under the scheme.
- 2.2.2. By law, there are defined groups of applicants who cannot be re-housed through the scheme. There are also exceptions or restrictions to an application which may apply.
- 2.2.3. Under the Housing Act 1996, local authorities must consider whether applicants are eligible for housing assistance. The council will apply the relevant legislation that is in place at the time of application.

2.3. The applicant's household

- 2.3.1. The council will decide in each case as to whether the people included in the application by the applicant will be considered as a part of the household for purposes of assessing housing need.
- 2.3.2. Any person wishing to be included as part of an applicant's household must satisfy the Council that they are a permanent member of the applicant's household and show that it is reasonable to expect them to reside with the applicant on a continuing basis.
- 2.3.3. The council will not consider the following as members of an applicant's household:
- Anyone who falls within legislation prohibiting them from having recourse to public funds or is an asylum seeker
 - Non-dependent children who have not lived within the household continually throughout their adult lives
 - Relatives who do not form part of the applicant's immediate family where there is no formal care arrangement; parents or step-parents, grandparents, brothers or step-brothers, sisters or step-sisters, aunts, uncles, grandchildren, nieces, nephews, cousins.
 - Any family member not resident in the UK at the time of the application.

- Any person who does not meet eligibility criteria
- Friends and acquaintances
- Lodgers
- Live in help
- Students living away from home with their own rent liability

2.3.4. Only dependent children that form a permanent part of the household can be considered. Only if an applicant is evidenced to have their child stay with them for four or more nights a week can they be classed as part of the applicant's household when making an assessment. Temporary arrangements or contact arrangements cannot be considered and household size will be determined upon evidence that any living arrangements are permanent, and the applicant can demonstrate to the council's satisfaction that they have full-time, permanent responsibility for the child. Where a formal residence agreement is not in place, the council will consider:

- Confirmation from the Courts regarding residency or parental responsibility.
- Who the children usually live with
- Who has financial responsibility for the children
- The length of time any arrangement has been in place
- Where the children go to school
- Any other relevant information

2.3.5. In cases where an applicant wishes to include their children in their Home Options application, this will not be considered where those children have adequate accommodation available to them elsewhere, for example with another parent.

2.3.6. Household members can only appear on one Home Options application.

2.3.7. Households that have been accepted to adopt or foster a child will be assessed as if they have assumed parental responsibility upon written confirmation from Norfolk County Council being provided.

- 2.3.8. Where an applicant feels that an additional bedroom is needed for a carer, this can only be considered where we have evidence of the need for permanent 24 hour care from a non-family member who is not part of your household and requires their own bedroom to sleep in on a continuing basis. 'Waking care' will not be taken into consideration. We would expect that the applicant would be in receipt of Carer's Allowance and Disability Living Allowance/Personal Independent Payment with the highest care/enhanced rate component. The carer must be recognised, employed by, or working on behalf of Adult Social Care and we would expect them to be a named person (unless your care is provided on a rota arrangement made by Adult Social Care or an agency on their behalf). The decision will be made by the assessment panel.
- 2.3.9. Where the family unit is not currently residing together, the assessment will be based on the part of the household that occupies accommodation that provides them with the most suitable housing providing there is a reasonable expectation that they should reside together.
- 2.3.10. Where an applicant has been assessed in accordance with the Mental Capacity Act 2005 as being unable to hold or to manage a tenancy, they may be suspended from the register until a suitable advocate is appointed to act on their behalf.
- 2.3.11. For an applicant to become a tenant and enter into a tenancy agreement, they must have the mental capacity to understand the contract. If an applicant does not have the capacity to understand the contract, an application should be made to the Court of Protection by an advocate for the tenancy agreement to be signed on their behalf.
- 2.3.12. Unborn children will not be considered as part of the assessment. A child cannot be added to an application until the applicant has provided a copy of the birth certificate.
- 2.3.13. For people in prison, applications can be made within 8 weeks of release if the client meets qualification and local connection criteria. In such instances the client does not need to apply for housing in person and applications will be accepted from a third party on behalf of a person in custody, for example by a Prison Resettlement Officer as part of a Resettlement Plan where third-party consent has been given.

2.3.14. Only household members that meet the eligibility and qualification criteria set out in this policy will be included in an application.

2.4. Eligibility

2.4.1. The Home Options team will determine the eligibility of an applicant, based on immigration status and habitual residence, by applying the legislation that is in place at the time of the application and the point of allocation.

2.4.2. Eligibility for Home Options depends on where the applicant normally lives ('habitual residence') and their immigration status. A person is not eligible if they are:

- subject to immigration control (with limited exceptions)
- classed as an ineligible person from abroad
- A person not habitually resident in the United Kingdom or required to leave the UK by the Secretary of State.

2.4.3. Eligibility is explained in detail within statutory guidance – "Allocation of Accommodation: guidance for local authorities" which is online at: Allocation of accommodation: guidance for local authorities - Guidance - GOV.UK (www.gov.uk).

2.4.4. Eligibility for housing assistance can be affected if there is a change in the immigration status of the applicant(s), and therefore eligibility for an allocation of housing will be kept under review. The applicant is responsible for informing the council of any change in their immigration status.

2.4.5. Applicants whose households include a person from abroad who is ineligible will not be afforded priority if they are only homeless or in housing need as a consequence of the presence of the ineligible person.

2.5. Qualification for housing in Norwich

2.5.1. The Localism Act 2011 allows councils to make local decisions about who qualifies for social housing in their area in order to ensure that local objectives and the needs of local residents are met.

2.5.2. The decision that an applicant does not qualify for an allocation may occur at the time of joining the Home Options scheme, at any time during the life of the application, at the time the applicant is allocated a property, or when the applicant has bid and has been short-listed for a property. The Home Options team will make the decision.

2.5.3. In accordance with statutory guidance and to ensure that the council's housing policies benefit local people, applicants must have been continuously resident in Norwich for at least the last two years. If applicants cannot provide satisfactory evidence that they meet the criteria, an application will not be taken. For household members to join an application and to be included in any assessment of housing need, the same criteria apply.

2.5.4. Exceptional circumstances will be considered. In such cases, the decision as to whether an applicant qualifies will be determined by a Housing Options team leader or manager, or by the council's assessment panel.

2.5.5. Examples are:

- Somebody who needs to live in Norwich as they have a significant need to be near specific medical care which is unavailable elsewhere.
- Applicants over 60 who have a specific need for sheltered housing in Norwich to be near medical care or family support unavailable elsewhere.
- The applicant needs to move to Norwich where failure to meet that need would cause extreme hardship to themselves or others
- Tenants of social housing needing to move to Norwich for work-related reasons where failure to meet that need would cause hardship, who can evidence that they meet the criteria set out in the 2015 Regulations (SI 2015/967).

- Households accepted as homeless under the Housing Act 1996 where the council has accepted a fully duty to rehouse
- Care leavers – Applicants aged 18-21 years (or up to 25 years old if they are pursuing a programme of education agreed in their pathway plan), who are owed a duty under Children Act 1989, section 23C
- Applicants fleeing domestic abuse who are living in refuge accommodation or who need to move urgently for the safety and security of themselves and any dependent children.
- Applicants that can demonstrate a lifelong residential connection to Norwich which has been broken for only a short time.
- In the examples above, a 'reduced preference' will be applied to the applicant's banding to ensure priority to long-term local residents.

These are examples and this list is not exhaustive.

2.5.6. Residents in prison, bail hostel, hospital or approved premises, or those households referred into or placed into any form of accommodation in Norwich by another agency or local authority will not gain a local connection and time spent in such premises will not count toward local connection.

2.5.7. Applicants whose only residential connection to Norwich is through further education or student accommodation will not be considered as having gained local connection. Student accommodation is that provided by an educational establishment or where a student exemption certificate has been provided for council tax purposes.

2.5.8. Where an applicant has only become eligible for housing assistance in the last two years, their local connection will commence from the date they became eligible.

2.5.9. Where an application is taken from a client who has not lived in Norwich continuously for the previous two years, and the client would normally be placed in a priority band, a 'reduced preference' will apply until the two year connection is established.

2.6. Exception to the criteria: Armed and Reserve Forces

2.6.1. The council is committed to ensuring that service personnel and their families have access to appropriate accommodation when they leave the British armed forces. Under the terms of the Armed Forces Covenant, to which the council is signatory, the local connection criteria will not apply to the following:

Those who are currently serving in the regular forces or who have served in the regular forces.

- Bereaved spouses or civil partners of those serving in the armed and reserve forces where (i) the bereaved spouse or civil partner has recently ceased or will cease to be entitled to reside in Ministry of Defence accommodation following the death of their spouse or civil partner and (ii) the death was wholly or partly attributable to their service.
- Existing or former members of the reserve forces who are suffering from a serious injury, illness or disability which is wholly or partly attributable to their service.
- Divorced or separated spouses or civil partners of Service personnel who are required to move out of accommodation provided by the Ministry of Defence.

Under these terms, the council can ensure that current and former service personnel in urgent housing need are awarded preference in line with the priority need bands.

2.7. Those who will not qualify: need considerations

2.7.1. Home Options policy aims to manage expectations realistically and to focus resources on those in most need of them. Therefore, having considered the provisions made in the Localism Act 2011, the following applicants will not qualify:

- Applicants who are tenants of scheme landlords who have made a 'right to buy' application on their property.

- Applicants who are tenants of scheme landlords and are in the process of carrying out a mutual exchange or have completed a mutual exchange in the previous 12 months.
- Applicants who have been housed through the scheme will not be able to reapply for Home Options for a 12-month period from the commencement of their new tenancy. This restriction does not apply where the household circumstances have changed and the property is no longer suitable or where there are extenuating circumstances.
- Applicants who have been housed through the council's private sector leasing scheme (Let NCC) or through a loan from the council's homeless prevention fund will have their Home Options application cancelled and will not be able to reapply for a 12-month period from the commencement of their new tenancy. This restriction does not apply where the household circumstances have changed and the property is no longer suitable or where there are extenuating circumstances.
- Clients who have been sponsored to enter the country in the last five years based on an undertaking given by a sponsor that accommodation was available (and where that sponsor is still alive)
- Applicants who own or have an interest in a property as a freeholder, leaseholder, a part-owner through shared ownership, including part commercial/residential property, in the UK or abroad will not qualify unless there are extenuating circumstances, as determined by a review panel. Examples of extenuating circumstances could be someone who requires sheltered housing in Norwich or someone who has been accepted as statutorily homeless.

2.8. Those who will not qualify: behaviour considerations

2.8.1. The council, scheme landlords and Norwich residents have a right to expect certain standards of behaviour. Where an applicant or a member of their household has a history of behaviour which is evidenced to have caused a detrimental effect to others, the Council may decide that the applicant does not qualify to be accepted onto the Home Options scheme.

2.8.2. Some examples of the type of behaviour that could mean that an applicant does not qualify for the Home Options scheme are:

- Serious rent arrears which, in the council's view, would entitle the landlord to a possession order.
- Causing deliberate damage to a property.
- Causing anti-social behaviour such as nuisance to neighbours, discriminatory behaviour or harassment, abuse, violence, or intimidation to the community or to council staff.
- Conviction for using or allowing a property to be used for illegal or immoral purposes
- Committing domestic abuse.
- Conviction for violent crime or the supply, use or possession of drugs.
- Conviction of a criminal offence in the property or in the locality of the property
- Eviction from hostel or temporary accommodation
- Being convicted of, issued with, or accepted a sanction for Benefit or Council Tax fraud within the last five years.
- Making a false statement in order to obtain accommodation
- Failing to provide relevant information that has been reasonably requested to verify an application for housing
- Failing to allow contractors to enter the property to carry out maintenance.
- Requesting or colluding with a landlord or family member to issue them with a Notice to Quit.

These are examples and this list is not exhaustive

2.8.3. The examples relate to both current and former tenancies and apply no matter who the landlord is, when they happened or what form of tenancy was held. Paragraphs 15.3 & 15.4, together with Appendix B, deal with the way in which applicants may demonstrate that they have addressed past behaviour in order to requalify.

2.8.4. Decisions are made on a case-by-case basis, with each case judged on its own merits.

2.9. Public protection arrangements

2.9.1. Applicants subject to multi-agency public protection arrangements can only access the register with the consent of the Housing Options manager. Each case will be considered on its own merits in determining whether an application will be accepted.

2.10. Assessment of applications

2.11. Legal background

2.11.1. All applicants who are eligible and who qualify for Home Options will be placed in the appropriate banding based on an assessment of their housing needs. This is to ensure that the council allocates homes to those in the greatest assessed need and to ensure that its legal obligations are met.

2.11.2. The council is required by law to give reasonable preference in the scheme to people with high levels of assessed housing need:

- People who need to move on welfare or medical grounds (including grounds relating to a disability),
- People who need to move to a particular locality of the city to avoid hardship to themselves or others,
- People living in unsanitary, unsatisfactory, or overcrowded housing, and
- People who are homeless within the meaning of the Housing Act 1996, and people who are owed a particular statutory duty by any local housing authority under section 190(2), 193(2) or 195(2) (or under section 65(2) or 68(2) of the Housing Act 1985 or who are occupying accommodation secured by any such authority under section 192(3).
- Former and serving members of the armed or reserve forces who have an urgent housing need or need to move because of a serious injury, medical condition or disability sustained as a result of their service

- Bereaved spouses and civil partners of members of the armed forces leaving services family accommodation following the death of their spouse or partner

2.11.3. Applicants outside the reasonable preference categories can also be given additional consideration to meet local priorities.

2.11.4. Applications are processed by the council's Home Options team, in accordance with this policy.

3. The housing need bands

3.1. Each application will be assessed to determine the level of housing need of the household and placed into one of five bands:

Emergency Band	Emergency priority
Gold Band	High priority
Silver Band	Medium priority
Bronze Band	Emergency/high/medium priority but with reduced preference
Standard Band	No priority

3.2. Banding will only be awarded where the applicant's circumstances have been verified.

3.3. An applicant's circumstances and therefore their level of housing need and banding is subject to change. As such, an applicant's Home Options banding is kept under continuous review.

3.4. Every applicant is responsible for ensuring that they provide correct and up to date information.

3.5. The criteria for being placed in each band are as follows:

3.6. Emergency band

3.6.1. This band is intended to meet the needs of applicants in extreme circumstances and will only be issued in certain situations where an applicant needs urgent re-housing to ensure their well-being or safety.

An applicant in Emergency band is expected to place two bids per week with the guidance of their housing adviser and accept the first suitable available property which they successfully bid for. As examples, circumstances where emergency status may be awarded include:

- An applicant has an extremely urgent medical need, as determined by a Housing Options team leader or manager or the council's assessment panel.
- Those applicants requiring urgent hospital discharge where their current accommodation is totally unsuitable for their needs
- Those applicants required to leave their homes as a result of an emergency prohibition order served in relation to the premises under the Housing Act 2004 or as the result of action taken by the Norfolk Fire and Rescue Service
- Other extreme circumstances as determined by the Housing Options manager or assessment panel.

3.7. Gold band

3.7.1. Homelessness and homeless prevention:

Applicants to whom the council has accepted a prevention of homelessness duty, where their circumstances have been confirmed and who are assessed by their housing adviser as likely to be in priority need. Applicants will have completed and kept to a personalised housing plan made with a housing adviser, will place, or have placed for them, two bids per week with the guidance of their adviser and will be entitled to one suitable offer of accommodation. In such circumstances the need to prevent or relieve homelessness may supersede other housing considerations. Refusal of the offer or failure to engage with advice will mean the council's duty is ended and gold banding will be removed.

3.7.2. Severe medical need:

Critical medical needs directly relating to the applicant's accommodation or need for accommodation as determined by a Housing Options team leader or manager, or by the council's assessment panel.

Medical priority is only awarded where, in the assessment of the panel, an applicant needs urgent re-housing due to a strongly evidenced, serious and enduring medical condition or disability, which is severely and permanently affected by their current accommodation.

Examples of severe medical need determining the award of gold band:

- The applicant is housebound through mobility issues and moving to alternative accommodation would alleviate this.
- The applicant's life is at risk.
- The applicant is unable to move around their current accommodation, and cannot access kitchen or bathing facilities
- A member the household is severely disabled and needs substantial adaptations to help meet their needs but these cannot be carried out in their current accommodation
- The applicant has a terminal illness and alternative accommodation would allow for suitable care to be provided
- The applicant has a severe and enduring medical condition which is significantly exacerbated by poor housing conditions and the accommodation cannot be repaired and no other remedies are available.
- Armed Forces members and veterans suffering from mental or physical ill health as a result of their service.

These are examples and this list is not exhaustive.

3.7.3. Welfare

Where the applicant or member of their household assessed by the panel as being grievously and adversely affected by their current accommodation and there is an urgent need to move for welfare reasons.

This may include situations such as:

- Infirmary due to old age
- The need to give or receive care
- A vulnerable applicant is being exploited within their accommodation putting them at risk
- To help avoid a residential placement where an applicant, with the necessary support mechanisms in place, is capable and best suited to independent living.
- The applicant is participant in a witness protection programme

This list is not exhaustive and other exceptional circumstances will be considered.

Assessment will be subject to a thorough investigation of all the circumstances by the council's assessment panel and the degree of priority awarded will depend on the circumstances of the case.

3.7.4. Housing Conditions

Applicants have no access to a kitchen and/or bathroom.

Or

A prohibition order or demolition order has been served in relation to the applicant's dwelling by the council's private sector housing team. This indicates that the property contains one or more category 1 hazards that probably cannot be remedied.

Or

An improvement notice has been served in relation to the applicant's dwelling by the private sector housing team and:

- The remedies that are needed to reduce the hazard will require the property to be vacated for a significant period

- The cost of the remedies is beyond the means of the applicant (where applicable)
- The remedies will make the property unsuitable for occupation by the applicant

In such cases the award of priority banding is dependent upon individual circumstances, which will be considered on a case-by-case basis by a Housing Options team leader or manager.

3.7.5. Overcrowding

Applicants lack two or more bedrooms.

3.7.6. Under-occupation/council interest

Tenants of council or scheme landlord accommodation that are under occupying by two or more bedrooms and prepared to move to significantly smaller accommodation or are occupying a substantially adapted property that they no longer require that the housing options manager assesses would be in high demand from applicants in need of those adaptations.

3.7.7. Decommissioning

Where a cabinet decision has been made to decommission a council property, gold band will be awarded to any tenant having to move home as a result.

3.7.8. Violence/Harassment

Where there is significant evidence of serious ongoing harassment or violence toward a household, where a change of accommodation within Norwich could be reasonably expected to alleviate the problem and there is no other remedy. In such instances banding will be awarded by a housing advisor working with the client to prevent their homelessness or as the result of a submission to the assessment panel.

3.7.9. Care leavers

Where an applicant is leaving local authority care and is assessed as needing to move on (as determined by a Housing Options team leader or

manager following the required evidence and risk assessment being submitted from Children's Services), where the applicant has completed a tenancy awareness course, support plan outcomes have been met and there is a suitable support package in place so that the council is satisfied that the applicant is able to successfully manage their own tenancy. Referrals can be accepted from four weeks before the applicant leaves care. Applicants will have completed and kept to a personalised housing plan made with a housing adviser, will place two bids per week with the guidance of their adviser and will be entitled to one suitable offer of accommodation. Refusal of the offer will mean that gold banding will be removed.

3.7.10. Let NCC

Where the applicant meets the criteria set out under the LetNCC tenant incentive scheme (Appendix C)

3.7.11. Multiple Needs

Applicants with a combination of medium needs.

3.8. Silver band

3.8.1. Homelessness and homeless prevention

Applicants to whom the council has accepted a prevention of homelessness or relief of homelessness duty, where their circumstances have been confirmed and who are assessed by the council's housing advice team as not likely to be in priority need. Applicants will have completed and kept to a personalised housing plan made with a housing adviser, will place or have placed for them two bids per week with the guidance of their adviser and will be entitled to one offer of accommodation. In such circumstances the need to prevent or relieve homelessness may supersede other housing considerations. Refusal of the offer or failure to engage with advice will mean the council's duty is ended and silver banding will be removed.

3.8.2. Medical

Significant medical needs directly relating to the applicant's accommodation or need for accommodation as determined by a Housing Options team leader, manager or by the council's assessment panel. For example:

- Applicants with an evidenced, enduring, and significant medical or disability problem which seriously affects their ability to manage in their current accommodation, where a move would resolve the issue and no other remedy is available.

3.8.3. Welfare

Where, in the assessment of the panel, the applicant or member of their household is evidenced as being seriously and adversely affected by their current accommodation, the issue cannot be remedied and there is a significant need to move for welfare reasons.

Assessment will be subject to a thorough investigation of all the circumstances and the degree of priority awarded by the council's assessment panel will depend on the circumstances of the case.

3.8.4. Housing Conditions

A hazard awareness notice has been served by the council's private sector housing team. In relation to a category 1 or 2 hazard at the applicant's dwelling and:

- The remedies that are needed to reduce the hazard will require the property to be vacated for a significant period; or
- The cost of the remedies is beyond the means of the applicant (where applicable); or
- The remedies will make the property unsuitable for occupation by the applicant
- A suspended improvement notice or prohibition order exists but a foreseeable change in the applicant's circumstances will cause it to become active and result in a high priority situation.

In such cases the award of priority banding is dependent upon individual circumstances, which will be considered on a case-by-case basis.

3.8.5. Overcrowding

Applicants lack one bedroom and those verified as 'sofa surfing'.

3.8.6. Under-occupation

Applicants in general stock council or scheme landlord accommodation, who are under occupying by one bedroom and are willing to move to smaller accommodation.

3.8.7. Children in flats or maisonettes

3.8.7.1 Applicants with a child or children aged ten or under and living in a flat or maisonette that does not have its own garden or private outdoor space.

3.8.7.2 Where a household includes a child or children aged six or under and the applicant lives in a property on the third floor or above where there is no lift access, an extra unit of priority will be added. Please note that any combination of issues related to children in flats would not normally exceed gold band.

3.8.7.3 This category will not be awarded for those children who were born when the current accommodation was accepted.

3.8.8. Let NCC

Where the applicant meets the criteria set out under the LetNCC tenant incentive scheme (Appendix C)

3.8.9. Rough sleeping

This priority will be applied where it has been confirmed that an applicant is sleeping rough, meets the qualification criteria and it has been assessed that there is no other accommodation available to them. The council will carry out a needs-led assessment and use professional judgement to engage and support people sleeping rough in each case. Priority will not be awarded when the client does not engage with the council's support or where accommodation has been made available to the applicant which they have chosen not to accept. Any banding determination will be made in conjunction

with the council's rough sleeping team. Applicants assessed as 'sleeping rough' will not be awarded additional priority on any other accommodation related factors.

3.9. Bronze band (reduced preference)

3.9.1. Reduced preference

Applicants with one of the assessed needs as detailed in emergency, gold, or silver band but who have been assessed for reduced preference as set out in section 4.1. In such cases, any criteria applied to the original banding will apply equally once reduced preference has been applied.

3.10. Standard band

All other applicants to the scheme will be placed in the standard band:

3.10.1. Adequately housed

Applicants who live in a property that is adequate to meet their needs in terms of property type, size, and facilities.

3.10.2. Supported Housing/Hostels

Applicants in supported housing/hostels and undergoing a resettlement programme and either not yet ready to move on or not engaging fully with the programme (based on the required evidence from an accredited supporting agency)

Or

Applicants in supported housing/hostels who do not participate in the hostel move on agreement.

3.10.3. Deliberate worsening of circumstances and becoming homeless intentionally

Applicants who are assessed by the council as having created or worsened their housing circumstances through their own actions or omissions, including those found to be intentionally homeless under homelessness legislation. This includes applicants who would otherwise be in a priority band.

Examples:

- An applicant giving up accommodation that was suitable or more suitable for them than the accommodation they have moved into and which it was reasonable to continue to occupy.
- An applicant creating overcrowding by allowing family and/or friends to move into their home, which has worsened their housing situation.
- An applicant moving into a property that was unsuitable for their household needs from the outset.
- An applicant being unable to continue to occupy accommodation due to their deliberate action or omission.
- Homeowners who have transferred or gifted their property to another person
- Applicants who have dispersed or deprived themselves of assets or capital which could have reasonably been used to secure housing.
- Unreasonably failing to follow advice given by the council in order to prevent homelessness.

These are examples and this list is not exhaustive

There is no time limit on the imposition of standard band on these grounds.

4. Methods of assessment

4.1. Reduced preference

4.1.1. Section 166A(5) of the Housing Act 1996, as amended by the Homelessness Act 2002, allows allocation schemes to give reduced preference where the behaviour of an applicant (or member of their household) affects their suitability to be a tenant.

4.1.2. In such circumstances, where tenancy conditions have been breached, an assessment will be made as to whether the applicant's behaviour

merits their not qualifying for Home Options or whether an application can be taken and reduced preference applied.

4.1.3. An applicant will be given reduced preference if the council is satisfied they or a household member owes housing related debts or who has failed to maintain a rented property in a proper and reasonable condition.

4.1.4. Housing related debt includes but is not limited to:

- Any current or former tenant rent arrears or charges for use and occupation owed to any local authority, registered provider or private sector landlord.
- Unpaid sundry debts owing to any local authority, registered provider or private sector landlord, including rechargeable debts or court costs.
- Any tenancy deposit or rent in advance loans provided by the council that remain unpaid; or tenancy deposit guarantees that have been honoured by the council and remain unpaid.
- Outstanding council tax debts.
- Outstanding re-chargeable repairs.
- Current and former housing related service charge arrears.
- Temporary accommodation charge arrears where that temporary accommodation was provided by the council.
- Any court costs incurred by the council or a housing association associated with any of the above debts

4.1.5. In exceptional circumstances, applicants will be given additional preference despite meeting one of the criteria outlined above. Examples of where this may be appropriate are:

- Where a scheme landlord seeks discretion as current rent arrears are caused by welfare reform due to under-occupation and the applicant is seeking to downsize, is keeping to a repayment arrangement and is working with the landlord to address arrears.
- Where a person is fleeing violence or domestic abuse and has rent arrears.

4.2. Significant financial resources:

4.2.1. Applicants that have sufficient income or savings which it would be reasonable for them to use to meet their housing need through other tenures whose circumstances determine that they would otherwise be in emergency, gold or silver band will have their priority downgraded to bronze band.

4.2.2. This assessment will be based on the following:

- The total income of the applicant/household
- Any capital available to the applicant/household
- Average property prices and rents in the area for the type of accommodation needed by the household
- The ability of the applicant/partner to rent a property in the private sector based on a realistic assessment of their financial position and commitments.
- The ability of the applicant/partner to acquire a mortgage and maintain required repayments based on a realistic assessment of their financial position and commitments.

4.2.3. Excluded from the above financial assessment will be any member of the Armed Forces who may have received a lump sum as compensation for an injury or disability sustained on active service.

4.3. Assessment of overcrowding

The council will use the following guidelines to assess the level of overcrowding:

- Assessments are made on the basis that the household is optimising the bedrooms available.
- Couples, married couples and civil partners are expected to share a bedroom/bedspace.
- A room intended as a bedroom but used for another purpose will still be classified as a bedroom.

- Where a child has a home elsewhere but chooses to live with another adult, this will not be counted when assessing overcrowding.
- A single person or couple can occupy one bedroom.
- Two children of the same gender are expected to share a bedroom up to the age of 16. When the oldest child is 16 years old, the family is classed as lacking one bedroom.
- Two children of different gender are expected to share a bedroom until the oldest child is 10 years old, at which time the family is classed as lacking one bedroom.
- Where adults aged 16 or over are sharing a room, but not living as a couple, they will be classed as lacking one bedroom.
- An infant under 6 months can share a bedroom with their parents.

4.4. Assessment of multiple/cumulative need

Where a household's circumstances meet more than one assessed housing need, this will be considered by the council when prioritising the applicant.

When a household has two or more housing needs within any one band, they will be moved one band higher to take into account the multiple needs. Any assessment of cumulative need will not normally exceed gold band.

4.5. Assessment of medical needs

4.5.1. Priority will be awarded based on information supplied by the applicant

4.5.2. The role of the assessment panel is to assess the degree of medical need relating to an applicant's current accommodation and whether this merits additional priority to move to a more suitable property.

4.5.3. A panel of team leaders and managers will assess each case on its merits to determine whether medical priority should be awarded. In complex cases the panel will include medical professionals.

4.5.4. Where an applicant's ill health is not directly related to their present housing, then medical priority will not be awarded.

4.5.5. Disabled applicants with specific accessibility needs receive priority over other applicants when bidding for adapted properties. Where the medical panel has assessed that an applicant or household member has a specific medical need for adaptations which are not and cannot be provided at their current home, their Home Options application will be given an accessibility rating, which gives additional preference over applicants who are not in need of adaptations when bidding for adapted properties.

4.5.6. Where adaptations to the applicant's home have been completed in the last 5 years in order to address a household medical need, no Home Options medical assessment will be considered unless there has been a significant change of circumstances.

4.5.7. Each household is restricted to submitting one Home Options medical assessment per annum unless there has been a significant change in circumstances such as a new diagnosis or significant deterioration in condition.

4.6. Assessment of welfare needs

4.6.1. This will be carried out by an assessment panel made up of Housing Options team leaders and/or managers.

4.6.2. Each case will be assessed on its merits to determine whether welfare priority should be awarded. The assessment panel will look at whether the situation is targeted, serious and enduring, whether it is directly affected by the applicant's present housing and whether it would improve if the applicant were re-housed.

4.6.3. In some instances, the assessment panel may award priority banding on a time limited basis and/or apply conditions to bidding.

4.7. Assessment of under-occupation

Priority for under-occupation will not be awarded where the applicant chose to move into a property which they would under-occupy and their circumstances have not changed.

4.8. Assessment of housing conditions

This will be carried out by the council's private sector housing team.
Assessment will be carried out in line with the Housing, Health and Safety Rating System and priority awarded as set out in the bands above.

4.9. Assessment of homelessness

This will be carried out by the council's housing advice and homelessness service in line with the Housing Act 1996 as amended by the Homelessness Act 2002 and Homelessness Reduction Act 2018. Priority will be awarded as set out in the bands above.

4.10. Supported Housing/Hostels

Applicants in supported living or hostels participating in the hostel move-on scheme will be allocated properties in accordance with that scheme (Appendix A)

4.11. Assessments for applicants who are members of staff or elected members of the council

4.11.1. Applications from elected members or members of their family will be dealt with by the Housing Options manager. The award of a priority band and/or an allocation to elected members or to members of their family will need to be authorised by the Chief Executive Officer.

4.11.2. Applications from staff members will be dealt with by the Housing Options manager. The award of a priority banding and /or an allocation to staff members will need to be authorised by the council's Director with responsibility for housing.

4.12. Determination of application date

All applications will be awarded an 'effective date' by the council. This is usually the date on which the Home Options application was made. The date will determine who is successful in being offered a property where two or more people from the same band bid on the same property.

4.13. Change in circumstances

4.13.1. If an applicant's circumstances change it is their responsibility to inform the council so that their application can be reassessed. Examples of a change of circumstances could include the serious deterioration in a medical condition, threat of homelessness or an increase in household size due to the birth of a child. Following the reassessment, if the applicant moves into a higher band their effective date will be the date that the council was notified of, or provided with evidence of, their change of circumstances. Alternatively, if an applicant moves into a lower band then the effective date will revert to the original date they applied for Home Options.

4.13.2. It is the applicant's responsibility to ensure that their contact details are kept up to date.

4.14. Revision of applications

Every Home Options applicant is sent a revision form on the anniversary of their application to ensure that their circumstances are kept up to date. They are required to update, sign and return the form to confirm they wish to remain on the housing register. The Home Options application will automatically be cancelled if the form is not returned.

4.15. Property size qualification

Each applicant will be assessed by the council, to determine what size of property they qualify for. It is expected that participating landlords will seek to maximise occupation of available properties. A general guide showing property size qualification for different household sizes is set out in a table at

Appendix E however, each participating landlord may choose to take account of local issues in determining what household size is eligible to bid for a property. This will be made clear at point of advertisement. Any potential affordability or housing benefit issues arising from this will be discussed with the applicant prior to their accepting the tenancy.

4.16. Notification of applications

Once a Home Options application has been assessed the applicant will receive notification from the council confirming the band in which they have been placed.

4.17. Cancellation of applications

4.17.1. Applications will be cancelled by the council for the following reasons:

- The applicant requests cancellation
- The applicant's circumstances change and they are no longer eligible
- The applicant's circumstances change and they no longer qualify
- The applicant fails to return a revision form
- The applicant is found to have made a false or deliberately misleading statement in connection with their application
- The applicant moves outside the Norwich boundary.
- The applicant has refused offers or failed to attend viewings on three occasions, where no other restrictions apply.

4.18. Refusals or failure to attend viewings

4.18.1. Where no other restrictions apply to the award of banding and an applicant has bid for three properties, which they have refused or where they have failed to attend the viewing without good cause, then their circumstances and banding will be reviewed. If these refusals are considered by a Housing Options team leader or manager to be unreasonable or without grounds, then the Home Options application will

be cancelled and no new application will be accepted for a minimum twelve-month period.

4.19. Misrepresentation or withholding of information

4.19.1. It is a criminal offence for anyone to try and obtain accommodation from the council by knowingly giving a false statement or withholding information.

4.19.2. If we suspect that an applicant has given false information or withheld information, we will investigate. The Home Options application will be suspended while the investigation is carried out.

4.19.3. Failure by an applicant, or someone acting at their instigation, to inform the council of changes to their application, contrivance of circumstances or the deliberate withholding, or misrepresentation of information relevant to their housing circumstances, will mean that the applicant will not to qualify for Home Options and their application will be cancelled for an indefinite period and can be reviewed only after a minimum twelve-month period. Any such action may also result in criminal prosecution. If found guilty the applicant could be liable to a fine and/or imprisonment.

4.19.4. The scheme landlord may seek possession of a tenancy that was granted as a result of a false statement and may also attempt to recover any costs incurred.

5. Accessing the housing options

5.1. Finding a home

Once applicants are registered on Home Options they can start looking for a social housing property of their choice.

5.2. Advertising of vacant properties

5.2.1. Properties will be advertised on a weekly basis.

5.2.2. Properties will be advertised in two main categories. These will be:

- For all applicants.
- For existing (transfer) tenants of the council and scheme landlords only.
- By these means the council will seek to ensure that at least 20% of allocations made through Home Options are to existing tenants.

5.2.3. Properties will be advertised in the following ways:

- In a newsletter
- At the council's website

5.2.4. The Home Options bidding cycle runs for the seven days from Wednesday midnight each week.

5.3. Promotion of other housing options

5.3.1. Information will also be provided about the other housing options we will be promoting through the scheme including:

- Help to stay in your current home (Disabled Facilities Grants, dementia grants and other discretionary loans etc.)
- Rent Deposit Schemes
- LetNCC scheme
- Discretionary Housing Payments
- Mutual exchanges
- Help to access properties for shared ownership

5.4. Property descriptions

5.4.1. Properties advertised will, wherever possible, carry a photograph of the property or similar and will have a description of the property. This description will usually include the following information, provided by the landlord:

- The type of property (house, flat etc.)
- The tenure of the property (social rented housing, affordable rent, shared ownership etc.)

- The number of bedrooms the property has
- The location of the property
- The level of accessibility the property has for people with mobility problems/wheelchair users
- Any services provided to the property e.g. wardens, caretaker etc.
- The heating type the property has
- Any age restrictions on the property (sheltered etc.)
- Whether pets are allowed
- Availability of outside space (garden etc.)
- The rent of the property and the service charges. Social rented properties can sometimes have two different rent levels of 'social rent' and 'affordable rent' and each landlord has their own criteria for which rent level applies to which type of property. This should be clearly explained on each advert, where this is relevant.
- Special information (location of bus routes/ other amenities etc.)
- Whether the property is available to all applicants or transfer applicants only

5.4.2. Applicants must qualify for the size of property as advertised.

5.4.3. The landlord will ascribe tenancy type(s) for their advertised properties.

5.5. Bidding/application process

Provided the applicant meets the stated qualifying criteria they can bid for the property by the deadline given.

5.6. Deadlines for bids

Bidding closes at midnight every Wednesday. Bids received after the specified deadline will not be considered unless there are extenuating circumstances. Any such retrospective bids must be agreed by the Housing Options manager and a record kept of the reasons for acceptance of the retrospective bid held on record for audit purposes.

5.7. Bidding methods

Applicants can bid in the following ways:

- On the website, www.norwichhomeoptions.org.uk
- Over the telephone to the Home Options team.

5.8. Disqualified bids

5.8.1. Applicants are restricted to making two bids for social rented properties per week. Applicants will not be considered for any property for which they do not meet the qualifying criteria. For example, a single person would not be considered for a three-bedroom property.

5.8.2. Where an applicant who has been awarded a priority banding to reflect a specific housing need has bid for a property which does not meet this housing need, their bid will not be considered. For example, an applicant in a priority band based on a medical need for a ground floor property will not be considered if they have bid for a house or upper floor flat.

5.9. Selection of the successful bids

5.9.1. At the end of the advertising cycle a shortlist will be drawn up from all applicants that have applied for a property. At this point the banding and qualification of any shortlisted applicant will be reviewed for accuracy.

5.9.2. The offer of accommodation will be made to the person in the highest band that meets the qualifying criteria. **If there is more than one applicant in the band, the offer will be made to any UK armed forces veteran within that band, followed by the applicant who has been waiting the longest within that band.** If the applicant with the highest priority refuses the property it will be offered to the next highest bidder and so on.

5.9.3. In order to maximise use of adapted properties, where a property has had adaptations to improve accessibility, the scheme landlord has the right to allocate the property to the applicant that has bid who is in greatest need of those specific adaptations at that property. As such, an occupational therapist may be invited to viewings of adapted properties to advise on suitability.

5.9.4. A risk and support needs assessment may be carried out. As a result, restrictions may be placed on the area or property which the applicant will be considered for. Applicants will not be offered a property where a risk to themselves or others has been identified.

5.10. Making the offer

5.10.1. The successful applicant will be contacted by the landlord whose property they have applied for to arrange an accompanied viewing. More than one applicant may be invited to the viewing. Photographic identification from the applicant will be required at the viewing.

5.10.2. Applicants will usually be contacted within three working days of the advert for the property closing. If an applicant cannot be contacted following multiple attempts the next person on the shortlist will be contacted. It is therefore important that all applicants ensure they are contactable or else they may lose out on a property they have applied for.

5.10.3. Applicants have 48 hours to decide whether to accept the offer of accommodation. If no response has been received after this time, the next person on the shortlist will be offered the property.

5.10.4. If an applicant refuses the offer, the property will be offered to the next on the shortlist, and so on until the property is let.

5.10.5. Scheme landlords reserve the right to carry out an assessment on applicants to ensure the particular property is appropriate. If the landlord deems the property not to be suitable for the applicant, the property would then be offered to the next applicant on the shortlist.

5.10.6. Offers of accommodation may be withdrawn if it is found that the information supplied by the applicant was incorrect or if they are deemed due to their behaviour to not qualify (e.g. if they have accrued rent arrears that were not previously known about).

5.11. Hostel move-on

The Norwich hostel move on agreement (appendix D) sets out how applicants in participant hostels and supported accommodation who meet the criteria will be allocated social housing.

5.12. Properties excluded from the scheme

The council reserves the right to exclude certain properties and housing schemes from the allocations system. Examples of where this may occur are:

- Where a property is needed urgently to deal with an emergency.
- Specialist housing schemes, for example Housing with Care Schemes will also be let outside the allocations scheme.

5.13. Direct lets

5.13.1. In certain circumstances the council will allocate properties directly to applicants, outside of the usual process.

5.13.2. Illustrative examples of direct lets are as follows:

- Where an allocation is required to ensure protection of the public, for example, following a decision made by a Multi-Agency Public Protection Panel meeting, or where an applicant has been referred as part of the witness protection scheme.
- Where the council or a scheme landlord has entered a special arrangement with a support agency in order to accommodate especially vulnerable or challenging clients. Any such arrangement will be governed by an agreement signed off by the Head of Housing.
- Where the tenant of a scheme landlord's home is being repaired and is not occupiable so that they need to be moved from the property on a temporary or permanent basis.
- Where a client has been accepted as statutorily homeless, they will be direct let the first suitable available property.
- As part of the council's 'hostel move-on' scheme (see Appendix D)

5.13.3. A tenancy may also be allocated by the council or scheme landlord, regardless of other priorities, where the applicant has enjoyed established occupancy of the property, has a reasonable expectation of a property of that type and would be a suitable tenant, (e.g. non-secure tenants, or carers or family members with no succession rights.) In deciding whether to make an offer of a tenancy the landlord will consider whether the

property is of a suitable size and type for the applicant's household and the conduct of the applicant in terms of rent arrears and tenancy conditions.

5.13.4. Decisions to allocate properties outside of Home Options will be authorised by the Housing Options manager and held on record.

5.14. Sensitive lets

5.14.1. Sensitive lets are used where a specific issue has been identified in a particular area or block, making a property unsuitable for allocation to some applicants. When considering a sensitive let, instead of allocating a property to the applicant at the top of the list, the landlord will consider the suitability of each applicant who has bid for the vacancy. This will be based on information held about the applicant and on knowledge of the property, its location or neighbours.

5.14.2. The council will only use sensitive lets in exceptional circumstances. In order to ensure that all decisions on sensitive lets are accountable, transparent and monitored, all decisions must be agreed by the Housing Options manager and the respective manager of the scheme landlord and a record held on file.

5.15. Local lettings plans

5.15.1. Local lettings plans are used by landlords to develop policies and letting arrangements that:

- Respond to local housing need and demand
- Help to suitably match applicants to properties; and
- Help them to achieve a balanced housing mix within a particular area.

The main aim of a local lettings plan is to build a strong and sustainable community.

5.15.2. Local lettings plans are generally used when allocating new build housing for the first time. New build developments are unusual in terms

of housing allocations because of the number of properties that are available for let in a short period of time in one area.

5.15.3. This makes sure that:

- new build programmes meet the widest possible range of needs; and
- the council avoids the creation of groups of vulnerable households in specific communities.

5.15.4. To make sure that all decisions on local lettings agreements are accountable, transparent and monitored, all decisions must be agreed by the Housing Options manager and the respective manager of the scheme landlord and a record held on file.

5.16. Sheltered Housing

5.16.1. Sheltered housing is accommodation designed specifically for older people. Residents may pay an additional charge for support services.

5.16.2. The minimum age for the landlord to consider an applicant for sheltered housing will be clearly stated when each property is advertised.

5.16.3. The council and scheme landlords may carry out a needs and risk assessment for customers who bid for sheltered housing properties, to ensure the services provided are appropriate to their needs. This will be done as part of the offer process.

6. Statement on equal access

6.1.1. The council and scheme landlords are committed to ensuring equality of opportunity in all elements of the scheme. This means that we seek to ensure that priority for housing is based on housing need and that housing policies are fair to all sections of the community regardless of age, disability, gender, marriage and civil partnership, pregnancy and maternity, race, religion or belief, or sexual orientation.

6.1.2. We want our services to be accessible to everyone who lives in Norwich. If you need extra help to be able to use our services, such as translation and interpretation services, large print or signing, please tell us.

6.1.3. All applicants for housing or rehousing may be asked to provide details of age, disability, gender, marriage and civil partnership, pregnancy and maternity, race, religion or belief, or sexual orientation. This is to allow us to assess the application properly as well as to monitor who is allocated housing, and to ensure that properties are being offered and allocated fairly.

6.2. Advice and assistance

The council will ensure that everybody in Norwich seeking housing can easily access the information and assistance they require to use the scheme effectively and we will provide advice on the range of housing options open to them. Staff will be available throughout office hours to provide advice and assistance on the full range of housing options available.

6.3. Vulnerable groups

6.3.1. Due to the nature of Home Options, particularly the need for applicants to be proactive in the process, the council realises it is essential that vulnerable and excluded people can participate effectively. The council will therefore ensure all relevant staff are well trained so that they can assist vulnerable applicants to access and use the scheme.

6.3.2. All literature will be available in a large font and written in plain and unambiguous language. The website is compatible with screen readers and has browse aloud capability.

6.3.3. The council will also hold an 'assisted applicants list' for those who, due to their vulnerability, require additional help with the scheme. This additional help includes helping applicants bid for available homes or sending the property brochures directly to people who cannot access the internet.

6.3.4. The 'assisted applicants list' can be accessed by applicants or their support workers informing the council. This service will only be available for the most vulnerable clients as determined by the council.

6.3.5. To ensure vulnerable groups are not being disadvantaged under the scheme, the council will monitor systems to ensure all groups are using the scheme successfully.

7. Reviews of decisions

7.1. Notifying an ineligible or non-qualifying applicant:

7.1.1. The council will notify an applicant in writing of any decision that they:

- Are ineligible for Home Options
- Do not qualify to join Home Options.

In each instance, the council will give clear grounds for the decision.

7.1.2. An applicant can ask for a review of certain decisions made regarding Home Options. These are:

- That they are not eligible or do not qualify
- Their band and effective date
- The type of property that they can bid/apply for

7.2. A request for a review of a decision must be made in writing within 21 days of receipt of the decision. The decision will be reviewed by an assessment panel made up of Housing Options team leaders and/or managers. The role of the reviewer is to ensure that policy has been correctly applied. We aim to complete all review and medical assessments within 56 days of the request but in some circumstances this timeframe may be extended. The applicant will be notified in writing of the decision.

7.3. In requesting a review of their qualification for Home Options, the applicant will normally be expected to show that they have addressed issues which caused them not to qualify for the scheme over a minimum 12-month period, clearly demonstrating to the council's satisfaction that their behaviour has been addressed and they are able to independently maintain a tenancy. The applicant's individual circumstances will be fully considered as part of any review and each case will be treated on its merits.

7.4. Where an applicant does not qualify for Home Options through rent arrears, the council has set out in Appendix B the repayment arrangements and

timeframes expected to be maintained in order for the applicant to demonstrate that the issue is being satisfactorily addressed.

7.5. Once a review has been completed, an applicant does not have the right to ask for a further review on the same grounds.

7.6. Complaints procedure

7.6.1. If an applicant is dissatisfied with any aspect of the management of their Home Options application, other than where a review can be made, they should follow the council's complaints procedure, details of which can be found at the website www.norwich.gov.uk.

7.6.2. The council will not accept a complaint for issues where there is or has already been a right of appeal, for example reviews of Home Options banding or qualification.

7.7. Local Government & Social Care Ombudsman

If a complainant is not satisfied with the action the council takes, he or she can send a written complaint to the ombudsman. A complainant must give the organisation an opportunity to deal with a complaint first, using its complaints procedure.

The Local Government & Social Care Ombudsman can be contacted at:

Tel: 0300 061 0614. Website: www.lgo.org.uk

8. Confidentiality statement

8.1. Norwich City Council is committed to protecting the rights of privacy and processing will be conducted fairly, lawfully and transparently in accordance with the General Data Protection Regulation (EU 2016/679) and all other applicable data protection law ('Data protection legislation').

8.2. We will ensure the personal information of all applicants (new, existing and former) is:

- Stored lawfully
- Processed in a fair and transparent manner
- Collected for a specific, explicit and legitimate purpose

- The data will be kept up to date and held until it is no longer required
- Shared only with other organisations for legitimate processing, the prevention of fraud or with the person's explicit consent. Our Privacy Notice can be located online at: www.norwich.gov.uk

8.3. When an application is made to Home Options, the applicant will be asked to give permission for information to be obtained from, or shared with, third parties, which would be required to enable the Home Options assessment or an allocation of housing to proceed.

8.4. If an applicant bids on a property advertised on Home Options, their data will be shared with the council or housing association that owns the property to enable the accurate and fair matching of people to properties to take place. Home Options partners and housing associations may also make enquires with council housing benefit departments and other agencies such as medical practitioners, DWP, support agencies, police and landlords to confirm the details provided by applicants.

9. Monitoring/changes to the scheme

9.1. Scheme monitoring

9.1.1. The scheme will be monitored directly by the Housing Options manager. The manager will, where necessary make recommendations for changes to the scheme, taking into consideration the following:

- Application and bidding data, property turnover and demand
- That the highest needs applicants and those who are vulnerable are using the scheme effectively
- The scheme's performance in meeting its agreed aims
- Feedback from applicants and stakeholders
- That the scheme continues to address local housing issues.

9.2. Changes to the scheme

The council reserves the right to expand, change or alter any element of the scheme, as and when required, to meet changes in housing need, capacity,

resources and legislation. Any major changes to the scheme will be carried out through a report of the Housing Options Manager to the council executive, following consultation with scheme landlords.

Appendix B - Equality Impact Assessment

EQUALITY IMPACT ASSESSMENT



NORWICH
City Council

What is being assessed	Norwich Home Options Allocation Policy	Status	Assessment of a statutory function update
Officer completing this form	Graduate Management Trainee		
Team	Home Options	Directorate	Communities and Housing
SLT sponsor	Executive director of communities and housing		
Date assessment commenced	28 th October 2025	Date of completion	4 th November 2025

Will the report this EqlA relates to go to Committee?

Scrutiny Committee (15th January 2025)

What are the main aims or purpose of the strategy, policy, plan, project, contract or major change to your service which you are considering?

Part 4 of the Housing Act determines that local authorities must have an allocation scheme to determine priorities between applicants for Norwich City Council owned (social) housing and to set out the procedure to be followed when allocating social housing in their area. In Norwich, the allocation scheme is called Home Options.

The current Home Options allocations policy dates from October 2021 and needs updating to incorporate new legislation and statutory guidance. The update also presents the opportunity to ensure that policy reflects local needs and issues.

This EqIA covers the entire policy, highlighting specific proposed changes to the policy:

- (a) local connection requirement increased from 6 months to 2 years
- (b) reduction in permitted social housing refusals from 5 to 3
- (c) prioritisation of armed forces veterans on housing shortlists within each band

How does it fit with other services and policies, and how does it support our [corporate priorities](#)?

Revisions to the Housing Allocations policy were developed in parallel with the development of the Norwich Homelessness and Rough Sleeping Strategy (2025–2030). These policy changes are closely aligned with the strategy and support the operational work of the homelessness prevention and relief teams.

The revised housing register eligibility and prioritisation criteria will promote social housing allocation to the most vulnerable local people who are engaged with home options, including those at risk of homelessness or who are currently homeless. These policy revisions will influence both who can join the register and how quickly they may be allocated housing.

The new housing allocation policy aligns to the “A Fairer Norwich” community-led plan priority: working to support local people and families so that they can face economic and social challenges. The policy aims to reduce inequality and the negative effects of poverty by prioritising social housing allocation for those who are the most in need within our city.

What is the reason for the proposal or change (financial, legal etc)?

The council has a statutory requirement to review and update their housing allocations policy in line with any significant changes to legislation, local priorities or local needs. In line with the update of the Homelessness and Rough Sleeping strategy (2025-2030), the allocations policy was reviewed and updated.

Who will be affected by this strategy, policy, plan, project, contract or major change to your service? <i>(Please tick all that apply)</i>	☒ Residents ☐ Visitors ☐ Council Staff ☐ Businesses ☐ Workers
Please state any specific client group or groups Specific groups impacted by this policy are: • Norwich City Council social housing tenants • Individuals applying for Norwich City Council home options • Individuals at risk of homelessness • Individuals experiencing homelessness	
Which wards will be impacted by your proposal? ☒ ALL Norwich City Council wards ☐ Bowthorpe ☐ Catton Grove ☐ Crome ☐ Eaton ☐ Lakenham ☐ Mancroft ☐ Mile Cross ☐ Nelson ☐ Sewell ☐ Thorpe Hamlet ☐ Town Close ☐ University ☐ Wensum	Does your proposal impact any of the council's Reducing Inequality Target Areas (RITAs)? ☒ Catton Grove ☒ Earlham ☒ Heartsease ☒ Mid Lakenham and Russell Street ☒ Mile Cross ☒ North City Centre ☒ Pilling Park ☒ Vauxhall Street ☒ West Pottergate

What outcomes do you want to achieve, why and for who?

Norwich has experienced significant population growth over the last decade and is the most densely populated district in Norfolk. Norwich, as with any city, faces some challenges including significant and entrenched inequality and deprivation: the latest data published by the End Child Poverty Coalition shows that between 2023-2024, 35.3% of children in Norwich were living in households below the poverty line.

As of October 2025, Norwich City Council owns a total of 14,211 properties, which includes 13,291 general needs homes and 920 sheltered homes. Despite this stock, the 2021 Greater Norwich Housing Needs Assessment projected a significant shortfall in social housing provision. Demand continues to outpace supply, particularly among Home Options applicants who are unable to access the increasingly unaffordable private rental sector.

The need for appropriate housing for vulnerable individuals and families is both urgent and well-evidenced. Homelessness is associated with significant health consequences for all experiencing it, including mental illness, infectious disease, heart disease, and early mortality (Crisis UK). Young people experiencing housing instability are more likely to be absent or excluded from school, while parents face heightened risks of depression and anxiety due to housing insecurity (Local Government Association, 2017). Older adults, particularly those over 60, are at increased risk of developing depression and dementia (Local Government Association, 2017). Temporary accommodation (TA) exacerbates these issues: two-thirds of TA residents report its negative impact on their mental and physical health (Shelter, 2023), and children residing in temporary housing for over a year are three times as likely to experience anxiety, depression, and infection compared to their housed peers (Shelter, 2006). Once within the social housing system, household changes can lead to overcrowding; a lack of available, larger homes prevents households from moving, thereby increasing their likelihood of mental illness, sleep disturbance, second-hand tobacco exposure, relationship breakdown, and poor educational attainment for children (WHO, 2018). A lack of stable housing additionally negatively impacts job and educational attainment, perpetuating the factors that entrap individuals in poverty and increase their need for social housing provision to prevent their homelessness (Crisis UK).

Certain groups are disproportionately affected by homelessness risk or its negative consequences, including families with children, those who are pregnant, army veterans, care leavers, refugees, those fleeing abuse, those experiencing severe mental illness, and those with complex, multiple needs (St Martin in the Fields UK).

To mitigate these harms and prevent homelessness among the most vulnerable through a very limited number of council-owned homes, the Home Options allocation policy must prioritise those in greatest need within Norwich. This prioritisation is primarily guided by statutory and legislative frameworks, supplemented by locally informed criteria that reflect emerging trends and community needs.

What evidence and data has been used for this assessment, including community engagement and consultation?

The new home options allocation policy will go through numerous stages of consultation and debate before sign-off.

The draft policy revisions, alongside its summary report and this EqIA, will be uploaded to Get Talking Norwich for the public to view, to allow engagement and comments from the community. The results of this consultation will be considered before the revised policy is assessed and debated within scrutiny committee. This EqIA will also be revised following public consultation. Amendments and suggestions from scrutiny committee will be implemented as appropriate before the final revised policy will go to the council's cabinet for sign off.

Who implements, carries out or delivers the policy, practice, service or function?

The home options, homelessness prevention, and homelessness relief teams.

Will anyone be disproportionately affected by what you are proposing, and/or will it create any benefits?

Due to additions to revised policy:

Populations impacted positively:

- Armed Forces Veterans

Populations with extra support in place to mitigate impact:

- Refugees
- Ex-offenders

Affected group	Key findings from analysis of data and evidence. Identify any gaps in data here	Level & type of impact:		Actions to mitigate impacts, maximise benefits or address identified gaps in data	By when dd/mm/yy
A group defined by age (60+)	No specific impact identified	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Those with physical access or mobility needs	Positive Impact: <i>(In line with current Home Options Allocation Policy)</i> Gold priority banding will be awarded to those in severe medical need who need urgent re-housing due to a strongly evidenced, serious and enduring medical condition or disability, which is severely and permanently affected by their current accommodation. This includes those who are housebound through mobility issues and moving to alternative accommodation would alleviate this, and those who have a terminal illness, where alternative accommodation would allow for suitable care to be provided.	☒ Positive impact ☐ Adverse impact	☐ Low impact ☐ Medium impact ☒ High impact	N/A – Allocation priority outlined in policy.	Ongoing

Those that identify as disabled	Extra support in place to mitigate impact: <i>(In line with current Home Options Allocation Policy)</i> People with learning disabilities or neurodivergence may face barriers in navigating the application process or understanding eligibility criteria.	☐ Positive impact ☒ Adverse impact	☐ Low impact ☒ Medium impact ☐ High impact	Extra support for this group: The council's Home Options team will continue to support all residents who need help with their housing needs, including those who require information in more accessible formats. We are committed to ensuring that everyone can access housing information in a way that meets their individual communication needs. The Home Options team hold a assisted applicants list for relevant applicants that require further support from the team to ensure they are not disadvantaged by the relative complexity of the Home Options application processes.	Ongoing
Gender reassignment	No specific impact identified	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Marriage and civil partnership	No specific impact identified	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Pregnancy and maternity	No specific impact identified	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Race/ethnicity	No specific impact identified	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Religion and belief	No specific impact identified	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A

Sex	No specific impact identified	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Sexual orientation	No specific impact identified	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Socio-economic hardship	Positive Impact: <i>(In line with current Home Options Allocation Policy)</i> Norwich has high levels of deprivation, with over a third of children living below the poverty line. Many residents face barriers to accessing private rental housing due to affordability, insecure employment, or benefit restrictions. These groups are disproportionately represented among Home Options applicants. As such, the Home Options team hold an assisted applicants list for relevant applicants that require further support from the team to ensure they are not disadvantaged by the relative complexity of the Home Options application processes.	☒ Positive impact ☐ Adverse impact	☐ Low impact ☒ Medium impact ☐ High impact	Overall, the policy aligns with anti-poverty objectives in the council's community-led plan. Its prioritisation of applicants in greatest housing need supports those experiencing poverty.	Ongoing
Refugees and Migrants	Extra support in place to mitigate impact on this population: <i>(Due to addition to revised policy: (a) local connection requirement)</i>	☐ Positive impact ☒	☐ Low impact ☒ Medium	Extra support for this group: Norwich City Council has formed a specialist refugee housing team that uses targeted grants to help individuals	Ongoing

	increased from 6 months to 2 years) Many asylum seekers are housed in Norwich-based accommodation while awaiting the outcome of their applications. If granted refugee status, they have 28 days to secure permanent housing. Although their residence in Norwich begins upon placement within asylum accommodation, the refugee-application process typically lasts significantly less than the two years required to qualify for the housing register, limiting their options for permanent accommodation upon exit.	Adverse impact	impact ☐ High impact	leaving asylum dispersal accommodation access private rental sector, thereby bypassing the continuous residence requirement for social housing. The council aims to continue to enable the success. provided by the refugee housing specialists.	
Armed Forces <i>(includes those who have served or continue to serve in our Armed Forces)</i>	Positive Impact: <i>(In line with current Home Options Allocation Policy)</i> As Norwich City Council has signed the Armed Forces Covenant, people with particular connections to the military don't need to meet local connection rules when applying for home options. This includes people currently serving or who have served in the regular Armed Forces; bereaved spouses or civil partners who must leave military housing after their partner dies, if the	☒ Positive impact ☐ Adverse impact	☐ Low impact ☐ Medium impact ☒ High impact	N/A – Allocation priority outlined in policy.	Ongoing.

	death was related to their service; former reserve force members with serious health issues caused by their service; and divorced or separated spouses or civil partners who are required to leave Ministry of Defence accommodation. Armed forces members and veterans are at a significantly risk of developing illness because of their service, resulting in their increased vulnerability. As such, gold priority banding will be awarded to Armed Forces members and veterans suffering from mental or physical ill health as a result of their service (where this is strongly evidenced, serious and enduring, and is severely and permanently affected by their current accommodation). <i>(Due to addition to revised policy: (c) prioritisation of Armed Forces veterans on shortlists)</i> UK Armed Forces veterans will also have the highest priority within any band they are placed in. On property shortlisting, where there is more than one applicant in the band, the offer will be made to any				
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	UK Armed Forces veteran within that band, followed by the applicant who has been waiting the longest within that band.				
Other groups – Ex Offenders	Extra support in place to mitigate impact on this population: <i>(Due to addition to revised policy: local connection requirement increased from 6 months to 2 years)</i> Housing ex-offenders upon their release from prison, alongside providing holistic support services, has been shown to reduce re-offending rates by 50% (Department of Levelling Up, Housing and Communities, 2023). It is important to note, however, that there is insufficient evidence to show that housing alone produces this effect (Ministry of Justice Analytical Series, 2025). Home Options eligibility requirements restrict ex-offenders from accessing social housing in two ways. Under the Home Options allocations policy, individuals detained in Norwich-	☐ Positive impact ☒ Adverse impact	☐ Low impact ☒ Medium impact ☐ High impact	Extra support for this group: A homelessness prevention referral can be made to the council by the probation service 8 weeks before an individual is released from prison, where work can begin to prevent their homelessness upon release. This mitigates the need for the applicant to present to the council themselves. Several housing alternatives are available to ex-offenders, including supported accommodation and private rentals. Norwich City Council has developed a specialist ex-offender housing team that utilises the Accommodation for Ex-Offenders (AfEO) fund (a central government fund that helps local authorities provide stable housing and support for individuals leaving prison,	Ongoing.

	based prisons, bail hostels, or approved premises do not gain a local connection to the area through residing in these premises. Ex-offenders additionally face exclusion from Home Options based on behaviour-based criteria including histories of anti-social behaviour, domestic violence, and convictions for violent crime.			thereby reducing homelessness and connected reoffending rates) to help them secure residence within the private rented sector. Since 2023, 91 ex-offenders have been housed through this approach. AfEO funding will end in April 2026, but the council aims to continue the success provided by the ex-offender housing specialists. Applicants excluded from Home Options if based on behaviour-based criteria may re-gain access if they can demonstrate that they have addressed these issues, as outlined in sections 5.0.4 and 5.0.5 of the policy.	
Other groups – Care Leavers	Positive impact: <i>(In line with current Home Options Allocation Policy)</i> Care leavers aged 18-21 years (or up to 25 years old if they are pursuing a programme of education agreed in their pathway plan) that are assessed as ‘needing to move on’ bypass the local connection requirements and are awarded gold priority banding, subject to	☒ Positive impact ☐ Adverse impact	☐ Low impact ☐ Medium impact ☒ High	N/A – Allocation priority outlined in policy.	Ongoing

	criteria.		impact		
Other groups – those fleeing domestic abuse	Positive impact: <i>(In line with current Home Options Allocation Policy)</i> Policy provides local connection exceptions and gold priority banding when safety needs are verified.	☒ Positive impact ☐ Adverse impact	☐ Low impact ☐ Medium impact ☒ High impact	N/A – Allocation priority outlined in policy.	Ongoing
Other groups – those living in overcrowded accommodation	Positive impact: <i>(In line with current Home Options Allocation Policy)</i> Gold priority banding will be awarded to applicants lacking two or more bedrooms. Silver priority banding will be awarded to applicants lacking one bedroom and those verified as ‘sofa surfing’.	☒ Positive impact ☐ Adverse impact	☐ Low impact ☐ Medium impact ☒ High impact	N/A – Allocation priority outlined in policy.	
Other groups – those at risk of homelessness, those who are homeless, and those	Positive Impact: <i>(In line with current Home Options Allocation Policy)</i>	☒ Positive impact	☐ Low impact	N/A – Allocation priority outlined in policy.	

who are rough sleeping	Where the council has accepted a homelessness prevention or relief duty for an applicant who does not hold a priority need, such applicants will be awarded a silver priority banding, subject to criteria. Applicants who are verified to be sleeping rough will be awarded silver priority banding, subject to criteria.	☐ Adverse impact	☒ Medium impact ☐ High impact		
Other groups – families with young children	Positive Impact: <i>(In line with current Home Options Allocation Policy)</i> Applicants with dependent children under the age of 10 who live in a flat or maisonette that does not have its own private outdoor space are awarded silver priority banding. Households that include children aged six or under, who live in a property on the third floor or above where there is no lift access, will move up one further priority band.	☒ Positive impact ☐ Adverse impact	☐ Low impact ☒ Medium impact ☐ High impact	N/A – Allocation priority outlined in policy.	

Are there any negative impacts that cannot reasonably be avoided?

Increasing the local connection requirement to two years will impact recent arrivals, refugees, and people placed in prison who return to Norwich. The change is a government guideline-based decision that prioritises limited social housing for long-term local residents. Targeted

mitigations will be provided, such as continued refugee private rental support, ex-offender private rental support, and exception routes and enhanced priority banding for care leavers, domestic abuse victims and army veterans.

How has the equality impact assessment informed or changed the proposal?

This EqIA has highlighted the key groups likely to be affected by the policy and reinforced the need for the continuation of the services which work to mitigate these impacts. These include the specialist rental support teams for refugees and ex-offenders.

What actions have been identified going forward?

Moving forward, the council will:

- Continue to fund and support the Refugee Housing Team to help refugees leaving asylum accommodation access private rented housing.
- Aim to sustain the positive outcomes achieved by Accommodation for Ex-Offenders (AfEO) team within the Home Options team beyond April 2026 when AfEO central government funding ends.
- Maintain the assisted applicants list and carry out regular outreach to ensure vulnerable residents receive appropriate support.

How will the impact of your proposal and actions be measured moving forward?

Review of allocation policy impact 1 year from implementation (February 2027)

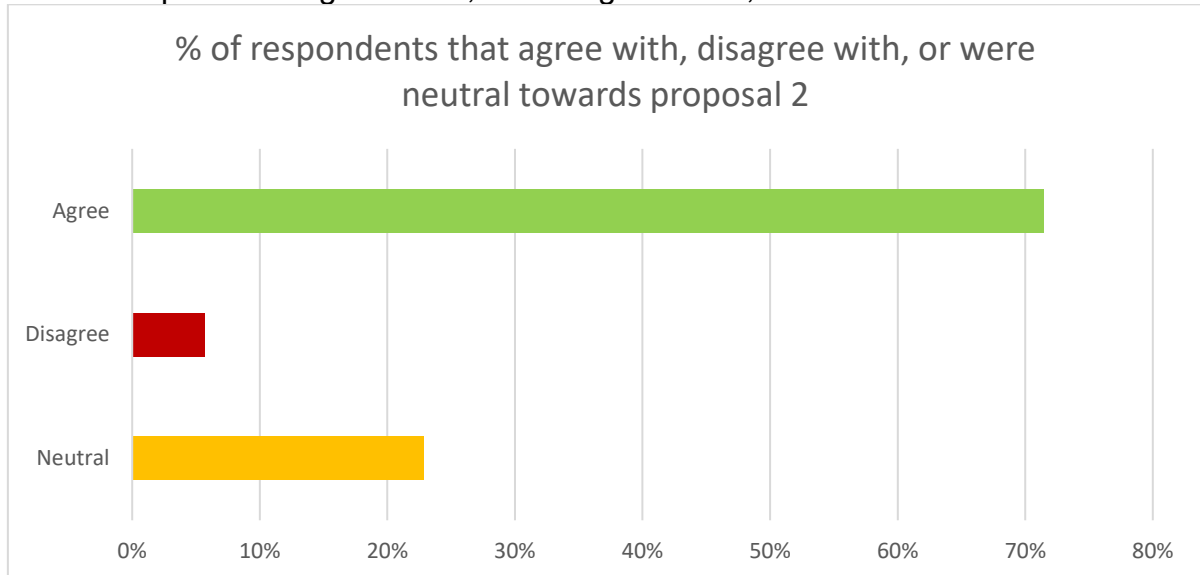
Negative outcomes action plan:				
Actions identified from EqIA	Target completion date (dd/mm/yy)	Responsible Officer (role)	Comments	Action complete
Continue and resource Refugee Housing Team Private Rental Sector grants to house refugees leaving asylum accommodation.	Ongoing	Home Options Manager		☐
Aim to sustain the positive outcomes achieved by Accommodation for Ex-Offenders (AfEO) team within the Home Options team beyond April 2026 when AfEO central government funding ends.	01/04/2026	Home Options Manager		☐
Maintain assisted applicants list and regular outreach to vulnerable applicants.	Ongoing	Home Options Manager		☐

Officer completing assessment	Date	04/11/2025
Senior leadership team sponsor	Date	05/11/2025
Equality lead (strategy team)	Date	04/11/2025

Appendix C – Consultation Response Data

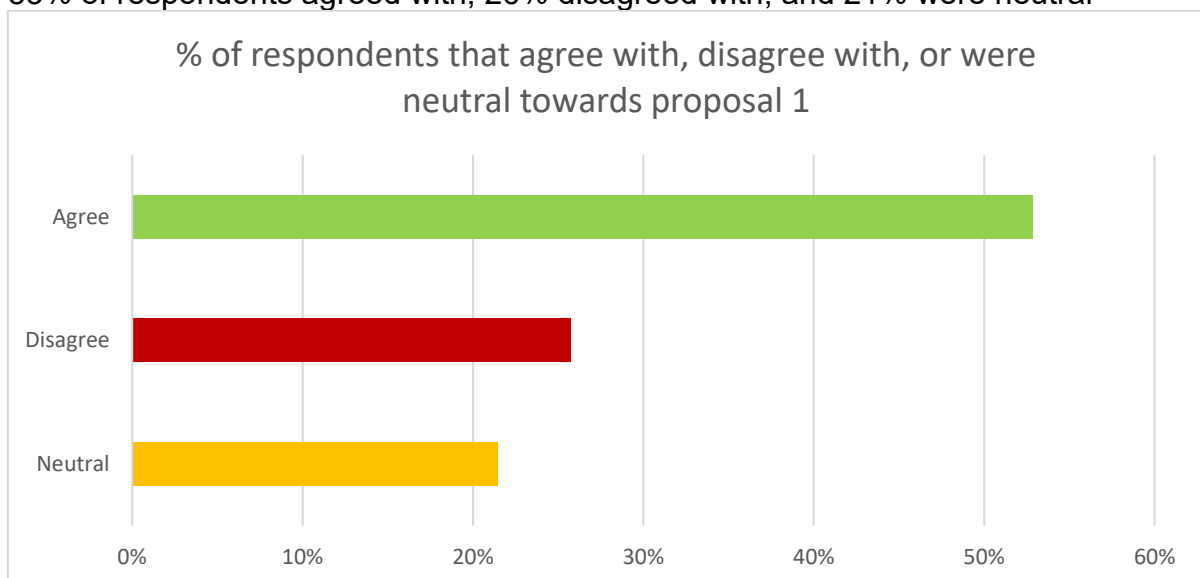
- 1) Advising non-priority-need applicants that they are unlikely to gain a home through Home Options, and to advise them regarding other routes to accommodation

71% of respondents agreed with, 6% disagreed with, and 23% were neutral



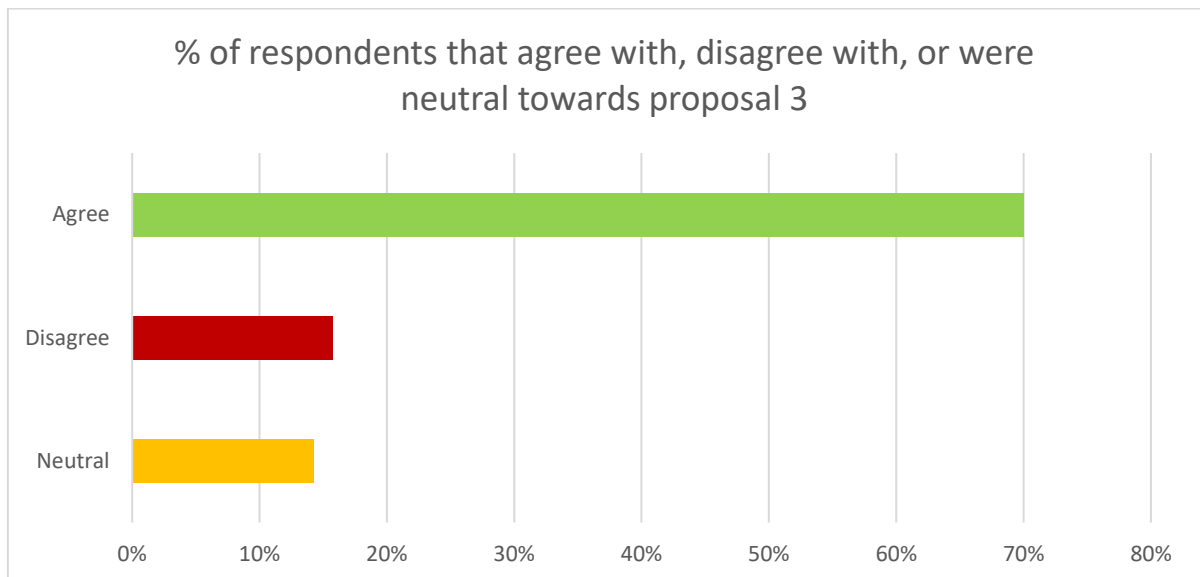
- 2) An increase in the local connection requirement from 6 months to 2 years, for an individual to be able to join the social housing register

53% of respondents agreed with, 26% disagreed with, and 21% were neutral



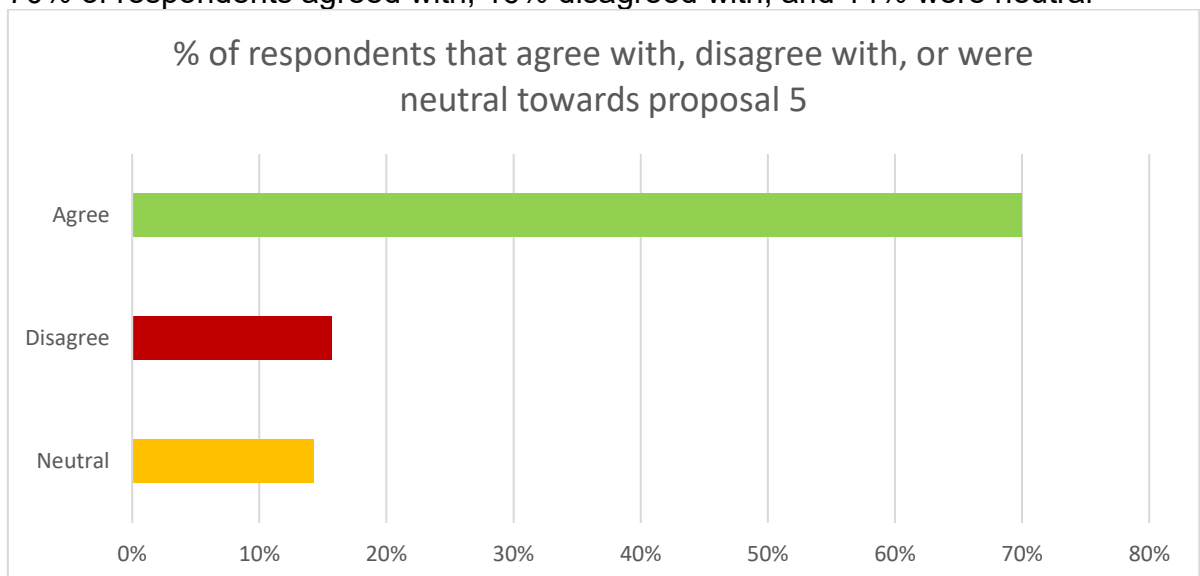
- 3) A decrease in the permitted number of property refusals from 5 to 3, before an individuals' application to Home Options is reviewed

70% of respondents agreed with, 16% disagreed with, and 14% were neutral



- 4) The creation of a rough-sleeping category within silver priority banding, whereby an individual who is verified as sleeping rough will be placed in silver band. Priority banding will be removed if the individual does not accept help or refuses suitable hostel accommodation.

70% of respondents agreed with, 16% disagreed with, and 14% were neutral



5) The automatic prioritisation of UK armed forces veterans within any band
37% of respondents agreed with, 20% disagreed with, and 43% were neutral.

